Empathy Through Cinema

ISHAAN KHATTER on the enriching experience of making the critically acclaimed, Oscar-bound drama *Homebound*

Q. *Homebound* is India's entry for Best International Film at the Oscars. What significance does it hold for you?
This film representing India on the world stage, which it already has [at Cannes and the Toronto film festival], is such a beautiful thing, because we are living in the most divisive times in the world. The film deeply humanises characters that are not often seen on screen. It is a devastatingly honest film, but also very empowering. It is a beautiful representation of our country and it gives the message of empathy, unity and understanding.

Q. What did filmmaker Neeraj Ghaywan tell you to do to help you imbibe the character of Shoaib, someone whose lived experience is completely alien to you?
Neeraj does a lot of prep for you. The first thing we started with after we did our first reading together was dialect work with Shreedhar Dubey, who helped us identify and get the nuances of Awadhi. Neeraj used to do improv exercises, which would go on forever. He doesn't want you to be crafty with a performance. The endeavour is to try and represent thousands of Shoaibs and Chandans out there. For that, you have to immerse and surrender yourself.

Q. Was there any reading material to prep?
Yes, he gave all of us Ambedkar's *Annihilation of Caste* to read so that we understand the historical context and how big a topic identity is.

Q. *Homebound* is a deeply poignant film which shows society's complicity in promoting prejudice. What insights did you gain from the experience of making it?
It urges you to try and understand how we got here in the first place. It stirred something inside me. There is complicity, but it is not because it is convenient, it's just sometimes due to a lack of awareness. Hopefully, it begets the question that it's enough. What I like is that the film is not an argument with the audience, but a conversation.

—with Suhani Singh



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